

EPISODE ONE PREMISE

FOUR KEYS • v1.0

★ THE EPISODE 1 CANDIDATE, and the strongest signal this project has ever recorded.
Stephen-ruled across 2026-08-27 and 28.

Working title: NEEDED. *"Five Keys After Midnight"* is retired as a title and kept as the origin. **Stephen: the 8.5 was the premise, not the title, and "after midnight" is nonsensical and constrains a timeline we do not want.** Recommendation: **THE FRIEND THEY MOURNED.** Alternatives: *Somebody Got There First* · *The Fourth Friend*. Not ruled.

0. WHY THIS ONE

Three readers, independently, scored roughly 190 one-line ideas. All three put this first.

Reader	Score	Note
Trish Szabo	10	★ The only ten awarded to anything, across the entire exercise
Alby, 22	8	Joint highest he gave
Stephen	8.5	"Definitely intriguing"

Mean 8.8, and top-ranked by every reader. Runner-up across the panel was *The Intruder Had a Key* at 8.0.

△ **Recorded because it matters more than this premise:** Stephen's highest-rated line of Claude's forty scored 7.5 with him and 5 and 2 with Trish and Alby. His taste and the target audience's diverge on some items, and the research puts the audience at 75 to 80 per cent women. **Never run a single-reader screen again on anything we are about to spend a month building.**

Origin: the seed came from Fable's or ChatGPT's second stinger batch, not from Claude's. **The winning premise was not mine, and the division of labour has been updated to reflect that.**

1. THE PREMISE, AS RULED

A woman is murdered. **Her death is recorded as an accident**, so there is no investigation.

Four of her friends receive keys after she dies, under an arrangement she made while she was frightened. The keys open one cupboard, where she hid proof that one of the four was planning to kill her.

★ **By the time they get there the cupboard is empty.** One of them arrived first. **They cannot prove anything and they cannot go to the police with an empty cupboard, and each of them now knows that one of the other three took it.**

They start meeting. They start working out which.

★★ **Then one of the four disappears.** A car somewhere coastal, a phone left behind, no remains. Presumed dead.

★★★ **And then, after he is already gone, a second one is murdered.**

The public account is that an unknown party took one friend and later killed another. The two who are left know something the police do not: it was one of the four. And the fourth appears to have been taken *before* the last murder, which seems to clear him.

So there are two of them left, and each believes the other did it.

★ **He is alive. Vanishing first was not an escape. It was an alibi for a murder he had not committed yet.**

Ally comes in after all of it. She does not prevent anything. **What her podcast establishes is that the man everybody has been mourning was never harmed, and that he relocated.**

2. THE SEQUENCE

#	What happens	Who knows
1	She is killed. Recorded as an accident	Him
2	The keys go out under her own arrangement	The four
3	The cupboard is empty. One of them got there first	The four
4	They meet. They start working it out	The four
5	★ One of them comes very close to the truth	★ Him, and this is the trigger
6	He disappears. Car, phone, no body. Presumed dead	Nobody
7	★ He kills her. She was chosen because of step 5	Nobody
8	Public account: a stranger took one and killed another	Everybody
9	Two left, each certain it is the other	The two
10	Ally arrives	—

★ Steps 5 to 7 are the ruling that defines him. He needed *a* keyholder to die to complete the alibi. He chose *that* keyholder because she had come very, very close.

What that hands the episode for free:

- The woman who died was **the best of the four** at seeing it.
 - ★ **The two survivors are the two who were furthest from the truth.**
 - They were spared because they were not good enough, and she died because she was. **Neither will ever say that to the other, and it sits underneath every conversation they have.**
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3. THE THREE CONDITIONS, ALL CLOSED

A. Her death was not treated as a murder at the time. Otherwise the arrangement goes straight to police and they open the cupboard first. A solicitor holding a murder victim's instruction hands it over, and any version where they do not is "*unbelievable incompetence*". **Recorded as an accident. No investigation, so nobody for the keys to go to.**

B. The cupboard is already empty. An innocent person who opens it takes the proof to the police within the hour and the episode ends at lead one. **What survives is not evidence, it is the certainty that one of the people in the room took it.** △ **Reject any version where a lock needs all four keys.** That is a puzzle-box device and puzzle-box thinking dropped the stinger ceiling from 8.5 to 7.5.

C. Somebody alive is at risk. ★ His safety rests entirely on being dead. The podcast is the only thing that can un-kill him. The proof that he is alive is **a person, not a record**: somebody in his new life knows him under another name and has no idea who he used to be. **The moment the podcast describes him, that person becomes the one in danger** — and Ally cannot stop without abandoning the case.

★ **Police cannot protect her, and it is not a contrivance: nobody knows who she is.**

4. WHY FOUR AND NOT FIVE

Stephen's ruling, and it improved the structure rather than just trimming it.

- **Three survivors is a committee. Two is a relationship,** and it is inescapable — every conversation in the episode is between two people who each believe the other murdered their friend.
 - **A reader can hold two suspects. Five names is a list; two is a question.**
 - ★★ **It hides the real answer behind a live one.** With five and a missing man, an audience guesses *the vanished one did it* in ten seconds. With two people actively accusing each other, there is a gripping surface question sitting on top of the true one. **The survivors' mutual suspicion is the misdirection.**
 - Ally becomes **the only neutral person either of them can talk to.** Two accounts to weigh, and what she does with what each tells her in private is a decision engine on its own.
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5. WHAT THIS PREMISE DOES THAT NONE OF THE OTHERS DID

Problem that killed or wounded earlier candidates	How this one answers it
No body at the top	A dead woman, a dead friend and a missing man, in the first sentence
No living jeopardy	His safety depends on being dead, and the podcast is what threatens it
Antagonist's least-cost action is to sit still	★ Sitting still and listening IS his best move, and it is lethal
A route is claimed closed that is not	Nobody can be protected because nobody knows her name. A wall the world supplies
Thin Havenbay or medium necessity	★★ A newspaper could not do this and neither could a detective. A serialised public investigation is a search engine he could never have built for himself. Strongest medium-necessity claim the project has produced
The agency gate needs engineering	Publishing advances the case and endangers her, every time, by construction
It reads as a chase, which the genre canon does not support	★ It is not a chase. It is a reclassification: the record says he is a victim

6. LENGTH AND SESSION STRUCTURE, Stephen-ruled 2026-08-28

The episode is 4 to 5 hours of play, in roughly 30-minute sessions, across a week or more. Eight to ten sessions. **Not a single-session story.**

Why, and it is not about content volume: a story that finishes in one sitting makes the merge board a toll booth. The alignment audit's rank-one open finding is that nothing demonstrates merging changes what a player believes, and a single-session story guarantees it never will. **Spread across a week, each session buys a real turn and the player's investment compounds.**

★★ **And this premise gets something no other candidate would have: the session boundary and the podcast episode boundary can be the same object.**

Ally publishes at the end of a session. The player closes the app. When they return they see what that publication did, **because in this story every episode narrows his search for the woman Ally is trying to protect.** The gap between sessions stops being dead air and becomes the thing happening to her. **It explains the interruption diegetically and makes the danger accumulate at exactly the rate the player plays.**

Sixteen leads over eight to ten sessions is about two leads a session.

△ **Costs to accept now:** 16 leads at 4 to 5 hours, times four episodes, is 16 to 20 hours of content with VO and art behind it. **That is a game, not a slice.** And **session one plays by different rules** — a fifth of installs die inside two minutes — so the first thirty minutes get designed against a separate brief.

7. WHAT IS DECIDED AND WHAT IS NOT

Decided: the sequence · four keys · the empty cupboard · the accident finding · the vanish-first alibi · the selected second victim · two survivors who suspect each other · Ally entering afterwards · the witness in his new life · length and session structure.

Open, and needed before or during the spine:

#	Question	When
1	The title	Any time. Recommendation in the header
2	Who the four are, as people	★ Before the spine. Fable brief, see below
3	What the proof actually was	Spine
4	What she said to the woman in his new life , and it has to be an ordinary sentence	Spine
5	How long between his disappearance and Ally , and what triggers her involvement now	Spine
6	Which of the two survivors brings it to her	Spine
7	Havenbay placement , and whether the coastal disappearance uses canon geography	Spine
8	Ruling questions on presumption of death and what reopens an accident finding	Spine

8. NEXT, IN ORDER

★ **Two briefs run in parallel BEFORE the spine, which is the sequencing lesson of this week.**

Two spines each cost a full day before the instrument found their hole; the pre-mortem found this premise's problems in one page.

1. **ChatGPT attacks the premise shape.** Four keys, vanish-first, the selected victim, the accident finding. **Before a spine exists, not after.**
2. ★ **Fable writes the five of them as people.** The dead woman and the four friends: how each knew her, what each of them had of her that the others did not, what they are like in a room. **Currently Fable only sees a spine after it is locked, so characters get built as functions and Fable inherits them.** The sharpest craft note of the week was that victims need lives more specific than illnesses and houses. **This is the fix, and it also serves the four-keys ruling, because "the two survivors were the two furthest from the truth" only lands if we know who they are.**
3. **Then the spine** (Claude), with step 1b and the recipient column run first.
4. **Then the thirteen objections.**
5. **Then one opening** (Fable).
6. **Then Trish, Alby and Stephen. ★ Three readers from now on, never one.**